

Q3 Quarter end

Operational Crisis Response Plan

Incident Window – 3:30pm to 5:00pm | Prepared by Bhavana Sudhakar Athavane

1. Situation Summary:

At 3:30 pm, on the last day of Q3, three time sensitive issues surfaced at the same time: an enterprise representing 15% of the quarterly target, is stuck in “Pending” provisioning; a nationwide 3PL outage is affecting 1200+ active order; and a payment automation bug has caused both duplicate and missed vendor payments. My approach is to stabilize the risk first, run the 3 workstreams in parallel and keep one clear owner and next action for each.

2. Triage Sequence and Rationale:

I would not work these strictly one after the other. All 3 start with the first 5 minutes. The sequence below reflects where I would spend my direct attention and what I would delegate to leaders, who already have the authority to act.

Priority	Issue	Why Now?	Immediate Action
Direct Focus	Revenue Bottleneck	Only issue with hard 5pm cut-off. Missing the cut-off may move recognition timing out of Q3	Pull in sales-ops, deal desk, finance and compliance
Parallel	Payment Corruption	Financial Exposure can increase if erroneous payments continue, so containment should happen immediately	Freeze automation, identify effected transactions and protect critical suppliers
Parallel	3PL Outage	Largest customer blast radius, but no single hour point of no return. Focus on reducing SLA or customer impact while the provider recovers	Activate backup capacity, prioritize orders and manage customer communications

Guiding Principle:

I triage by deadline, reversibility of the impact and whether my direct involvement can materially change the outcome. Revenue gets my direct attention, because it has the clearest hard deadline. The other two issues are delegated to owners with authority to act. If engineering capacity becomes the constraint, I would prioritize the work, tied to 5pm deadline, while keeping the payment automation fully contained.

3. Executive Communication – CEO / CFO

Timing: Send at 3:40pm, then provide the next update at 4:30pm or sooner if the situation changes.

Subject: Urgent – Q3 Closeout risk: 3 concurrent ops issues

To CEO / CFO,

We have 3 concurrent operational issues, and separate workstreams are already active. No executive decision is needed from you right now; I will escalate immediately if those changes.

1. Revenue – The enterprise contract (approx. 15% of Q3 target) is stuck in provisioning. I am personally driving this with sales ops, deal desk, finance and compliance to complete provisioning through the fastest path before 5pm. Finance will confirm the applicable billing and recognition treatment.

2. Vendor Payment Errors – The payment automation has been halted. Finance and Engineering are identifying the effected payment population, reconciling against the last known good data and prioritizing validated payments to suppliers.

3. 3PL Outage – Our primary provider is down nationwide and 1200+ order is affected. Operations have activated backup capacity, for the highest priority orders and customer success is preparing proactive delay notices. We are tracking the cost and SLA impact.

The next consolidated update: 4:30pm or sooner, if a material decision is required.

Thanks.

4. Process Recovery - 3PL Outage

I selected the 3PL disruption for the detailed recovery plan because it has the largest customer blast radius and depends on getting the first few coordination steps right. The goal is to reduce customer impact while the provider works on its outage.

- Declare incident: Head of Fulfillment becomes Incident Commander and opens a war room with Operations, Customer Support and Sales
- Freeze the blast radius: Pull all orders routed to the affected 3PL and segment them by ship-by date, SLA tier and customer criticality.
- Activate backup capacity: Trigger pre-negotiated backup 3PL/carrier capacity for the highest-risk orders first, after confirming intake capacity.
- Re-route by priority: Move already-breaching and business-critical orders first. Keep lower-risk orders queued for normal routing if backup capacity is constrained.

- Communicate proactively: Send delay notices with the latest credible ship estimate before customers have to ask; use existing goodwill-credit policy where applicable.
- Track exposure: Track orders rerouted, SLA exposure, expedite premiums and credits so Finance has a clean EOD impact estimate.
- Reassess: Get a firm outage ETA from the provider, re-check at 30 minutes and hourly, and scale backup capacity if recovery is delayed.

Payment incident in parallel

Finance freezes the automation immediately, Engineering preserves logs and the last known-good state, and Finance builds the affected-transaction list. Duplicate-payment recovery and validated emergency supplier payments happen only through controlled Finance processes; full reconciliation and root-cause work follow the immediate containment.

5. Operational Leadership

Composure - I would make sure every issue has an owner and a first action within the first five minutes, so nothing sits in limbo while I focus on the revenue deadline.

Trade-offs - I would spend my own time on the issue with the clearest hard deadline and delegate the other two to leaders who already have the authority to act. My role on those tracks is to unblock decisions and check progress, not become the bottleneck.

Accountability - Each workstream gets one accountable owner, a next checkpoint and a clear escalation trigger. That keeps the team moving without requiring every decision to come through one person.

Communication - I would communicate bad news early, along with what we are doing about it. Leadership should not have to wait for an incident to be fully resolved before hearing about it.

6. Quarter-End Operating Timeline

Time	Revenue	Payments	3PL
3:30	Launch all three workstreams	Pause affected payment automation	Confirm 3PL outage + provider contact
3:40	Engineering/Finance/Compliance checkpoint	Scope affected payments	Segment critical orders
3:45	Executive status update	Exception report underway	Backup capacity confirmed

4:00	Select fastest compliant recovery path	Prioritize critical suppliers	Begin rerouting where capacity exists
4:15	Revenue go/no-go checkpoint	Reconciliation continues	Review customer/SLA exposure
4:30	Final provisioning push/escalate if needed	Controlled corrective payments	Provider ETA + capacity reassessment
4:45	Finance/Compliance checkpoint	Controls remain in place	Escalate critical unresolved
5:00	Document outcome + accounting treatment	Continue controlled remediation	Continue fulfillment recovery

7. Success Measures

- No additional erroneous vendor payments are generated.
- Critical suppliers are protected from service interruption.
- The enterprise contract follows the fastest available compliant path, with Finance determining the appropriate billing and recognition treatment.
- The 3PL backlog is actively reduced, rerouted or prioritized based on customer/SLA risk.
- Customers with material delays receive timely, accurate communication.
- Every workstream has a clear owner, next action and escalation path.
- Root causes are documented and preventive changes are assigned owners and deadlines.

Operating principle

Move quickly, stay organized, and do not create a bigger problem while solving the immediate one.

8. Bonus Challenge - Compliance Decision

Decision: Hold the contract for the standard 24-hour compliance and data-privacy audit. I would not authorize the manual override.

Executive Decision Note - To: VP of Sales and Head of Compliance

The 5 PM deadline is commercially important, but a clean track record with this client tier does not remove mandatory privacy/compliance control. I would not authorize a manual override that bypasses the required audit. Instead, I would escalate immediately to

Compliance leadership for the fastest authorized review available and have Finance confirm the appropriate accounting treatment if provisioning cannot be completed today.

This keeps the company moving toward the quarter-end objective without creating an unapproved compliance exception. I would also document the decision and timeline so the incident can be reviewed and the process improved afterward.

9. SOP Modification

Proposed change: Add a "Revenue-Deadline Fast-Track Audit" path for contracts flagged as quarter-critical.

1. At contract signature, Sales flags deals that are expected to require provisioning within 48 hours of quarter close.
2. The workflow automatically opens the Compliance review and notifies Sales, Finance and Engineering.
3. Compliance provides a pre-scheduled same-day expedited audit slot when the deal meets the criteria - this is a faster review, not a bypass.
4. The system tracks a shared deadline and escalates overdue approvals before the final day becomes a scramble.

Why this works

It changes the process from "contract -> provisioning -> compliance blocker -> quarter-end escalation" to "contract -> compliance + provisioning in parallel -> validation -> billing." The control stays in place; the process becomes faster and more predictable.

10. Final Takeaway

My goal in this situation is not to personally solve three problems at once. It is to create enough structure that the right people can solve them quickly: contain anything that can get worse, keep the time-sensitive work moving, communicate clearly, and protect the controls that keep a short-term deadline from becoming a larger business problem